

Casting for the Flats

Student Lesson Plan — 14-Hour (2-Day)

Two-day immersion · Day 1: Steps 1–7 · Day 2: Steps 8–10 + film analysis.

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STRATEGY

Know the target · know the cast ·
know the safety rules

LINE CONTROL

Pause · power · path · haul timing

TACTICS

Quick delivery · strip set · minimum
false casts

Loop Control · Elliptical Cast · Wind Safety · Double Haul Timing · Shooting Line · Quick Delivery · Line Management · Boat Casting · Film Analysis · Practice Design

NAME

DATE

THE TWO RULES NEVER CHANGE — Rule 1: what the rod tip does, the line does. Rule 2: don't forget Rule 1.

THE STRIP SET RULE — Rod tip stays LOW. All force comes from the line-hand strip. Never lift the rod on the first take.

DAY 1 — STEPS 1–7

1 Loop Control & Foundational Stroke Review

55 min

CUE

The Two Rules don't change for saltwater. A tight loop is your most important piece of gear.

WHAT WE COVER

- The Two Rules never change in saltwater — Rule 1: what the rod tip does, the line does. Rule 2: don't forget Rule 1. Every saltwater fault traces back here.
- Saltwater demands a tighter loop than freshwater — the wind rewards tight loops and destroys wide ones. A tight loop is not optional; it is survival equipment.
- The fundamental stroke must be automatic before adding saltwater complexity — distance, wind, and moving targets amplify every existing fault.
- Common freshwater habits that kill saltwater performance: wide loops, soft stops, arm-dominated stroke, insufficient haul timing.
- Rod selection: fast-action 8–10 wt for most flats species. The fast tip produces tighter loops under load but demands precise stop timing — a late stop on a fast rod creates tailing loops.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Loop diagnosis warm-up: 10 overhead casts, student names the fault in each using Rule 1 before instructor comments.
- Tight loop drill: target 20 ft, loop must pass through a 12-inch hula hoop held by partner — 8 of 10 before advancing.
- Fault isolation: instructor introduces one deliberate fault (soft stop, concave path, arm-first) — student identifies it within 3 casts.
- Self-correction round: student casts, self-diagnoses, self-corrects without instructor input — 5 consecutive casts.

- ☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

2 Elliptical / Oval Cast — The Saltwater Workhorse

1h 5m

CUE

The ellipse keeps the heavy fly on the safe side and your tippet intact. Pantomime the oval first.

WHAT WE COVER

- The Elliptical / Oval Cast (Hans Gebetsroither, Traun River, mid-1930s): backcast made sidearm, forward stroke made more upright — rod tip describes an oval/ellipse during the pause.
- Also called the Belgian Cast or Constant Tension Cast — constant tension through the oval keeps heavy flies and sink tips under control at all times.
- Why it dominates saltwater: heavy flies (Clousers, Deceivers, crab patterns) cannot be safely handled with a standard overhead backcast — the hook can come back into the angler.
- The ellipse keeps the heavy fly from 'helicoptering' on the backcast, which causes shock-loading, leader failure, and hook injuries.
- Wind from behind: low sidearm backcast (haul hard), high forward stroke — the oval path uses the wind on the forward stroke rather than fighting it.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Elliptical pantomime without rod: slow-motion arm path traces the oval — instructor verifies the shape is an ellipse, not a straight line or loop.
- Strip of yarn: tie a 3-inch strip of yarn to the hook — student observes the yarn during the oval cast vs. overhead cast. The yarn shows the fly's behavior.
- Weighted rig comparison: cast a lightly-weighted fly with overhead, then oval — compare the turnover and safety of each.
- Tilt drill: cast the oval with wind from the left, then right — student adjusts tilt direction to keep fly downwind of their body.

- ☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

3 Safety — Wind, Hook, and Boat Casting Awareness

45 min

CUE

The fly must always travel DOWNWIND of your body. Always. No exceptions.

WHAT WE COVER

- The cardinal rule of saltwater casting safety: the fly must always travel DOWNWIND of the angler's body — always. No exceptions.
- Wind from the casting-arm side (right wind for right-handers): the most dangerous condition. The fly can blow across the body into the angler's face, neck, or ear.
- The Comb the Hair cast: for wind from the casting-arm side, the rod is tilted to the off-shoulder side — rod tip passes well outside the opposite shoulder like brushing hair. Fly travels downwind of the body at all times.
- The Barnegat Bay Cast (backcast presentation): turn 180° and present on the backcast — fly always blows away from the angler. The most reliable safety cast in strong casting-arm wind.
- Two forward cast, backcast delivery: make two forward false casts to build line speed, then deliver on the backcast. Keeps the fly on the safe side throughout.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Four wind direction safety quiz: instructor calls a wind direction, student names the safety cast and demonstrates the rod tilt before making the cast.
- Comb the Hair drill: 10 repetitions with wind from casting-arm side (use a fan) — verify rod tip passes outside the off-shoulder on every cast.
- Barnegat Bay delivery: present on the backcast to a target — 4 of 6 on target at 40 ft.
- Boat obstacle simulation: set up chairs and cones simulating a guide platform and motor — student must navigate the cast around obstacles without hitting any.

- ☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

4 Double Haul Timing — Rod Butt Passes Vertical

1h

CUE

Haul when the rod butt passes vertical — not before, not after. That one timing cue changes everything.

WHAT WE COVER

- Mac's double haul timing rule: the haul begins when the casting stroke is past the halfway point — specifically when the rod butt passes vertical on each stroke. This is the most precise timing cue in saltwater casting.
- Why this timing is critical: hauling too early (before the rod butt passes vertical) pulls the line before the rod is loaded — you are fighting the rod, not helping it.
- Hauling at the correct moment (as butt passes vertical) maximizes the rod's flex during the power application — the haul and the rod's stored energy release simultaneously.
- The haul is a sharp, short pull — 12–18 inches in saltwater. Not a long, slow pull. Sharp and short at exactly the right moment triples line speed.
- The return: after the haul, the line hand must immediately return toward the reel before the next stroke begins. The return is the most neglected element.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Rod butt metronome drill: instructor calls 'haul' at the exact moment the rod butt passes vertical — student develops the feel through external timing before internalizing it.
- Haul isolation: practice the haul motion without casting — feel the sharp 12-inch pull and immediate return as a standalone muscle memory drill.
- Distance comparison shoot: 5 casts without haul, 5 with correctly timed haul — student measures and records the difference in feet.
- Fault identification: instructor intentionally hauls early (before vertical) and late (after vertical) — student identifies which sounds/feels different from the water.

- ☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

5 Shooting Line — O-Ring, Line Hand & Maximum Distance

50 min

CUE

Release at the stop, feather with the O-Ring. The ring gives you control and distance simultaneously.

WHAT WE COVER

- The O-Ring: line hand forms a ring (thumb and index finger) around the line during the shoot — maintains light tension that prevents tangles while allowing maximum line speed through the guides.
- Why the O-Ring matters in saltwater: stripped line on a boat deck in wind will tangle without guidance from the line hand. The O-Ring solves this without sacrificing distance.
- Feathering the landing: the O-Ring allows gentle deceleration of the line at the end of the shoot — the angler closes the ring slightly as the fly reaches the target, killing the remaining energy and producing a soft landing.
- Lift and Point: after shooting, rod tip lifts and points directly down the rod leg — reduces guide friction, extends the shoot by 3–8 feet.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- O-Ring isolation drill: strip line, form the O-Ring, shoot — no casting at all. Feel the line acceleration through the ring and the feathering control.
- Feathering drill: shoot to a target at 50 ft — the fly must land within a 3-ft circle. The feather determines precision.
- Lift and Point measurement: cast with and without Lift and Point — measure the difference in shoot distance.
- Maximum distance shoot: student attempts maximum O-Ring distance — instructor observes for guide friction, ring tension, and timing of release relative to the stop.

- Timing of the shoot: release the line at the moment of the stop (E phase) — releasing before the stop loses the stored energy; releasing after dissipates it.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

6 Quick Water Delivery Casts — Minimum False Casts to Target

1h 5m

CUE

The fly catches fish. The air does not. Minimum false casts is not laziness — it is strategy.

WHAT WE COVER

- The rule of the flats: every false cast is a lost opportunity and a spook risk. The fly is not catching fish while it is in the air.
- Minimum false cast principle: the goal is to deliver 40 ft in 2–3 false casts and 60 ft in 3–4 false casts. More than that is poor preparation, not good casting.
- The ready position: 10–15 ft of fly line outside the rod tip + 20–30 ft of pre-stripped line in the basket or on the deck. This pre-loaded ready position allows the first false cast to immediately load the rod with 30+ ft of line.
- The pick-up and lay-down: for short shots (under 40 ft), a single pick-up and delivery with one haul is ideal — minimum time in the air.
- The water haul pickup: when the fly and line are on the water, a smooth roll-cast-style pickup loads the rod with water tension before the backcast — one less false cast needed.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Clock drill: partner calls a clock position and distance — student delivers within 5 seconds. Repeat at 40 ft and 60 ft.
- False cast countdown: 40-ft target, student must deliver on cast 3 or fewer. Timer running. 5 attempts.
- Water haul pickup: fly on the water, guide calls a position — student uses water haul pickup and delivers in 2 false casts.
- 2-forward-1-back sequence: drill the specific sequence as a standalone skill before integrating into the clock drill.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

7 Fly Line Management — Deck, Wet Towel & Shooting Basket

45 min

CUE

Line management problems cause more missed fish than casting problems. Respect the deck.

WHAT WE COVER

- Line management is the difference between fishing and untangling. On a flats boat, the line is your ammunition — keep it ready at all times.
- The wet towel method: a wet towel on the bow provides friction that keeps stripped line in place during wind. Lay coils in figure-8 patterns, not circular coils — circular coils twist and tangle.
- Shooting basket method: a stripping basket worn at the waist or placed on the deck catches stripped line cleanly in any wind condition. The most reliable method for wading or windy decks.
- Pre-stripping: before the boat poles into a flat, strip out 20–30 ft of line and arrange it carefully on the deck or in the basket. Never start a saltwater cast from a dead reel.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Figure-8 coil drill: strip 40 ft of line and arrange in figure-8 coils on a towel — timed and evaluated for tangle-free shoot.
- Basket management: strip 40 ft into a stripping basket — make a cast and verify the line shoots cleanly without tangling.
- Obstacle avoidance: strip line on a simulated deck with placed obstacles — student must identify and route around each one.
- Re-strip drill: make a 40-ft cast, retrieve, and re-strip the line into shooting-ready position in under 60 seconds.

- The double leader trick: the loop-to-loop connection between fly line and leader is doubled and held between the little finger of the line hand and the rod — this reference point tells the angler exactly where the shooting head ends, allowing consistent hand placement on every cast.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command

☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

DAY 2 — STEPS 8–10

8 Never Cast Over the Boat — Off-Side & Alternative Delivery Methods

45 min

CUE

Never cast over the boat. Know your three solutions before you need them.

WHAT WE COVER

- The fundamental rule: never allow the backcast or forward cast to pass over the guide, any other person, or the boat's structure. This applies even when the fish is on the difficult side.
- The 'difficult side' problem: for a right-handed angler, a fish at 9 o'clock (left) requires the line to cross over the guide on the poling platform if a standard cast is used.
- Solution 1 — Two forward casts, backcast delivery: make two forward false casts building line speed, turn on the final backcast and present. The fly travels away from the guide on every stroke.
- Solution 2 — Comb the Hair (off-shoulder cast): for fish slightly behind the difficult side, the rod is tilted over the off-shoulder so all line travel is on the downwind/off-boat side.
- Solution 3 — Barnegat Bay cast: present completely on the backcast for fish directly at or behind the difficult side. Accurate and completely safe.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Two-forward-one-back drill: set up a 'guide obstacle' (chair) and fish position requiring crossing. Student must deliver using only the two-forward-one-back method.
- Three-solution carousel: instructor calls a fish position and wind direction — student selects and executes the correct solution from the three options.
- Low sidearm accuracy: cast fully sidearm to a target at 40 ft with the line staying below 3 ft off the ground throughout — accuracy maintained.
- Boat-obstacle simulation: cast around a full boat mockup — every person and object is a no-cast zone.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

9 Film Analysis — Before/After & Fault Library

1h

CUE

The camera doesn't lie and it doesn't have an ego. What you see is what the fish sees.

WHAT WE COVER

- Film analysis is the fastest correction tool in saltwater casting instruction — a student who sees their own fault on video corrects it 3x faster than one who only hears a description.
- Saltwater-specific faults to identify: wide loops in wind (Rule 1), late haul timing (pre-vertical vs. post-vertical), line tangle source, backcast trajectory (too low = hits water; too level = crashes the forward cast), delivery timing (too many false casts).
- Baseline film: 10 casts at the start of the program, sealed for comparison at the end. The before/after reveal is the single most motivating moment in the curriculum.
- Common saltwater fault vocabulary: 'helicopter fly' (tailing loop with a heavy fly), 'wind tangle' (loop blown open by wind), 'early release' (shooting before E phase), 'tourist timing' (more than 4 false casts to 60 ft), 'trout set' (lifting instead of strip setting).

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Baseline vs. current side-by-side: student narrates what changed in their own language, using course vocabulary.
- Fault identification round: 5 unlabeled clips of common saltwater faults — student names the fault and its Rule 1 origin.
- Personal fault library creation: written in session, instructor reviews and countersigns.

- The personal fault library: each student identifies their top 3 saltwater faults with specific corrections. This is the self-coaching tool that persists after the course.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

10 Practice Design, Integration & the Saltwater Ready Angler

45 min

CUE

Two skills cover 80% of saltwater failure: loop control under wind and false cast reduction. Know yours.

WHAT WE COVER

- The ready angler standard: arrive on the flats able to deliver 40 ft in 2 false casts, 60 ft in 3–4 false casts, in any wind direction, with clean O-Ring management and a strip set ready before the fly lands.
- Pre-trip preparation checklist: practice in wind (not in a parking lot on a calm day), practice the clock drill at both 40 and 60 ft, practice the Comb the Hair cast, practice the Elliptical Stroke with a heavy fly, check all line connections and leader.
- The 2% rule: two skills account for 80% of saltwater fishing failure — loop control under wind and false cast reduction. Fix these two things before any trip.
- Structured practice schedule: 3 sessions per week, 20 minutes each. Each session focuses on one skill only. Mixing skills in one session produces half the learning of focused practice.
- The strip set: mentioned throughout the course — now drilled explicitly. After the fly lands, the rod tip stays low and all hook-setting force comes from the line hand stripping. Never lift the rod on the first take.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Strip set drill: instructor strikes the line by hand — student strip sets with rod tip low and line hand only. 10 repetitions until reflexive.
- Pre-trip simulation: 5-minute continuous session — clock calls, wind conditions, line management, strip set. No pauses, simulated guide pressure.
- Written practice plan: 30-day plan created in session. Two skills maximum. Specific location, specific target distances, specific cast counts per session.

☐ I can demonstrate this on command ☐ I can self-diagnose the fault without instructor help

My Saltwater Fault Library

Identify your top saltwater-specific faults. Use course vocabulary — Rule 1, haul timing, ellipse, safety cast.

SALTWATER FAULT #1

WHAT IT LOOKS / FEELS LIKE

MY SALTWATER CORRECTION

WHICH RULE WAS BROKEN

Rule 1 / Rule 2 / Haul timing / Safety (circle one)

SALTWATER FAULT #2

WHAT IT LOOKS / FEELS LIKE

WHICH RULE WAS BROKEN

Rule 1 / Rule 2 / Haul timing / Safety (circle one)

MY SALTWATER CORRECTION

SALTWATER FAULT #3

WHAT IT LOOKS / FEELS LIKE

WHICH RULE WAS BROKEN

Rule 1 / Rule 2 / Haul timing / Safety (circle one)

MY SALTWATER CORRECTION

Quick Reference — Saltwater Masterclass Module One**WIND SAFETY — FLY DIRECTION RULES**

Wind from line-hand side	Keep line low. Haul + Kentucky windage. Sidearm cast.
Wind from casting-arm side	Comb the Hair cast OR Barnegat Bay cast. Fly always downwind.
Wind from behind	Elliptical stroke. Low sidearm backcast, high forward stroke.
Wind into the face	Tight loop + full haul. Squat cast. Cast line on the surface.

QUICK DELIVERY BENCHMARKS

40 ft delivery	2–3 false casts maximum. Ready position: 10–15 ft outside rod tip.
60 ft delivery	3–4 false casts maximum. Water haul pickup saves one false cast.
Clock positions	12 = straight ahead · 3 = right · 9 = left · 6 = behind. Deliver within 5 seconds of call.
False cast rule	Every false cast beyond minimum = one additional spook opportunity.

DOUBLE HAUL TIMING — MAC'S RULE

When to haul	Rod butt passes vertical on each stroke. Not before. Not after.
Haul distance	12–18 inches, sharp and short. Not a long, slow pull.
The return	Line hand returns to the rod immediately after the haul. Most neglected step.
Distance increase	Correctly timed haul = 30–50% more distance than an unassisted cast.

SAFETY RULES — NEVER NEGOTIATE THESE

Fly direction	Fly must always travel DOWNWIND of the angler's body. Always.
Over the boat	Never cast over the guide, any person, or boat structure. Ever.
Comb the Hair	Rod tilts to the off-shoulder: fly path clears the angler's body downwind.

Barnegat Bay	Present on the backcast: fly travels away from boat and angler.
Hook safety	Barbless hooks strongly recommended. Call “casting” before every cast.